

Alma Matters

Connecting Students and Alumni to Fund What Matters

Product Overview & Feature Specification

Version 1.0 | March 2026

1. Executive Summary

Alma Matters is a community-driven platform that bridges the gap between what students need and what alumni can provide. Students post requests for projects, resources, and programmes at their institution; the community validates these requests through upvoting and moderation; and alumni choose to fund the initiatives that matter most to them.

Mission: To empower every student to shape their educational environment — and give every alumnus the ability to make a direct, tangible difference to the institution they love.

Traditional alumni giving is impersonal: a cheque to a general fund with little visibility into impact. Alma Matters flips this model. Every donation is tied to a real student request, championed by peers, and verified as legitimate — creating a trust chain from need to contribution to outcome.

2. The Problem

2.1 Students

Students regularly identify gaps in their educational experience — missing equipment, underfunded clubs, inaccessible tutoring, or the absence of specific programmes. Their feedback is often routed through slow bureaucratic channels with no guarantee of action and no visibility on progress.

- No clear mechanism to propose new resources or programmes
- Proposals to administration lack peer-validated social proof

- Students feel disconnected from the institution's funding decisions
- Grassroots initiatives stall due to lack of financial support

2.2 Alumni

Alumni want to give back, but many feel disconnected from the impact of their contributions. Generic donation campaigns rarely communicate where money goes or what it achieves.

- Donations to general funds feel anonymous and low-impact
- No mechanism to direct funds to causes that personally resonate
- Limited ongoing connection to the life of the institution
- Difficulty knowing which student needs are genuine and pressing

2.3 Institutions

Universities and schools struggle to maintain meaningful alumni engagement over time. They also lack structured tools for aggregating student feedback on resource gaps in a transparent, data-driven way.

- Alumni engagement declines sharply after graduation
- Student needs are fragmented across departments and societies
- Development offices lack granular data on what students value most

3. The Solution

Alma Matters is a three-sided platform — students, alumni, and institutions — with each group playing a defined role in a clear, transparent workflow.

Role	Action	
Students	Post requests for projects and resources; upvote peers' ideas	
Moderators	Screen posts for validity and appropriateness before they go live	
Alumni	Browse verified, community-backed requests and fund those they care about	

Core Value Proposition: Every pound or dollar donated on Alma Matters is traceable — from the student who asked, to the community that endorsed it, to the alumnus who funded it, to the outcome it produced.

4. Core Features

4.1 Student Request Board

The heart of the platform. Any verified student can submit a request for a project, resource, programme, or piece of equipment. Requests are structured, searchable, and tied to their institution.

Feature	Description
Request Form	Title, description, category (e.g. Arts, Sport, Welfare, Academic), estimated cost, and supporting materials
Upvoting	Peers upvote requests they agree with, surfacing the most-needed items to the top
Categories	Predefined tags help alumni filter by the areas they care about most
Progress Tracking	Requests show funding status — open, partially funded, or fully funded
Outcomes	Once funded, students post an update on what was achieved

4.2 Moderation & Screening

Before any request is visible to the alumni community, it passes through a moderation layer to ensure authenticity and appropriateness.

Feature	Description
Student Verification	Posts are only accepted from verified institutional email addresses
Content Review	Moderators (institutional staff or trained volunteers) review each submission for relevance and legitimacy
Spam Detection	Automated filters flag duplicate or off-topic submissions before human review
Appeals	Students whose posts are declined receive clear feedback and may resubmit

Transparency	Moderation decisions are logged, providing accountability and audit trails
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4.3 Alumni Discovery & Funding

Alumni access a curated feed of verified, community-backed student requests. The interface is designed to make finding personally meaningful causes intuitive and rewarding.

Feature	Description
Personalised Feed	Alumni filter by institution, graduation year, subject area, or request category
Funding Tiers	Alumni can make a partial contribution or fully fund a request
One-off & Recurring	Donations can be one-time or set as monthly contributions to a cause type
Impact Dashboard	Alumni see a real-time summary of projects they have funded and their outcomes
Naming & Legacy	Optionally, funded projects can acknowledge the alumnus (e.g. 'Music room renovated with support from J. Smith, Class of 2009')
Gift Aid (UK)	Eligible donations include Gift Aid declarations to maximise value

4.4 Institutional Dashboard

Institutions receive a dedicated administrative view to manage their presence on the platform, oversee moderation, and access analytics.

Feature	Description
Request Analytics	View trending requests, funding gaps, and category breakdowns
Alumni Engagement	Track giving rates, top donors (anonymised), and engagement over time
Moderation Console	Review, approve, or decline pending student submissions
Reports	Export data for development office reporting and board presentations
Branding	Customise the institution's profile page with logos, imagery, and messaging

4.5 Notifications & Communications

Automated touchpoints keep all parties informed and engaged throughout the lifecycle of a request.

- Students are notified when their post is approved, upvoted, or funded
- Alumni receive updates when a project they funded posts an outcome
- Weekly digest emails summarise new high-upvote requests for alumni
- Institutions receive alerts for flagged content or unusual activity
- All communications are opt-in with granular notification preferences

5. Key User Journeys

5.1 Student Journey

Step	Action
1. Register	Sign up with institutional email; account verified automatically
2. Post a Request	Complete a structured form with title, description, category, and budget estimate
3. Await Moderation	Request is reviewed, typically within 48 hours
4. Go Live	Approved post appears on the board and is visible to the community
5. Community Endorsement	Fellow students upvote the request over time
6. Funding	An alumnus selects the request and makes a contribution
7. Post an Update	Once funds are received or the project is complete, the student posts an outcome update

5.2 Alumni Journey

Step	Action
1. Register	Sign up and verify alumni status via graduation year and email or institutional records
2. Set Preferences	Choose institutions, subject areas, and cause types of interest
3. Explore Requests	Browse a personalised feed of verified student requests

4. Fund a Cause	Select a request, choose an amount, and complete a secure payment
5. Track Impact	Receive updates on the project and view it in their personal impact dashboard
6. Share	Optionally share funded projects with their network to encourage further support

6. Trust & Safety

Trust is the foundation of Alma Matters. Donors must have confidence that every request is genuine; students must know that moderation is fair; institutions must be assured that their reputation is protected.

Principle	Implementation
Verified Identities	Both students and alumni verify via institutional or personal email; institutional records integration available for premium tiers
Human Moderation	All student posts are reviewed by a human moderator before going live — no post can be funded without approval
Escrow Funding	Donated funds are held in escrow and released only when a project update is confirmed by the student or institution
Dispute Resolution	Any party can flag a concern; a clear escalation process is in place with defined SLAs
Data Privacy	All personal data is handled in compliance with GDPR (UK/EU) and relevant local data protection law
Transparent Fees	Platform fees are clearly disclosed at the point of donation; no hidden charges

7. Business Model

Alma Matters operates a transparent, low-friction revenue model that aligns platform incentives with positive outcomes for all parties.

Revenue Stream	Description
Transaction Fee	A small percentage (e.g. 5–8%) is applied to each successful donation to cover platform operations and payment processing

Institutional Subscription	Schools and universities pay an annual licence fee for the institutional dashboard, analytics, and premium branding features
Premium Alumni Features	Optional enhancements such as personalised impact reports or legacy naming are available to alumni donors
Grant & Partnership Income	Potential income from educational charities, foundations, and philanthropic bodies aligned with the mission

Pricing Principle: The platform will never charge students to post a request. Student participation must remain entirely free to preserve the integrity of the community.

8. Technology Overview

Alma Matters is designed as a mobile-first web application, accessible on all devices without requiring a native app download. The architecture prioritises security, scalability, and ease of integration with institutional systems.

Component	Approach
Web Platform	Responsive Progressive Web App (PWA) accessible on desktop, tablet, and mobile
Authentication	OAuth 2.0 with institutional SSO support (e.g. Microsoft 365, Google Workspace)
Payments	Stripe integration for secure card payments; Open Banking support planned
Notifications	Email and in-app push notifications; Slack/Teams integration for institutions
Data & Analytics	Institution-level dashboards built on a real-time analytics layer
API	RESTful API to allow institutions to embed Alma Matters functionality into existing portals or apps
Hosting	Cloud-hosted with SOC 2 compliance; EU data residency available for GDPR requirements

9. Product Roadmap

Phase	Scope
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Phase 1 — MVP	Student request board, upvoting, moderation queue, basic alumni funding, and payment processing
Phase 2 — Engagement	Alumni impact dashboard, outcome updates, personalised feeds, and notification system
Phase 3 — Institutional	Full institution dashboard, analytics, branding customisation, and SSO integration
Phase 4 — Scale	Multi-institution support, Gift Aid automation, API for third-party embeds, and mobile app
Phase 5 — Community	Alumni network features, mentorship matching, and event tie-ins for reunion giving campaigns

10. Why Alma Matters, Why Now

Several converging trends make this the right moment to launch Alma Matters.

- Alumni giving rates at UK universities declined from 20% in 2010 to under 9% in recent years, despite total alumni wealth growing substantially.
- Students report increasing frustration with the pace of institutional change, particularly around resources and extracurricular provision.
- Platforms like GoFundMe, Patreon, and Kickstarter have normalised direct, transparent community funding — the behaviours Alma Matters relies on are already familiar.
- Universities face growing pressure to demonstrate the return on alumni investment, and need tools that create visible, reportable impact.
- The post-pandemic cohort of students is more vocal about institutional shortfalls and more comfortable organising online to address them.

The Opportunity: Alma Matters sits at the intersection of EdTech, civic tech, and philanthropy — a largely unoccupied space with clear demand from both students and alumni donors.

11. Summary

Alma Matters is more than a fundraising tool — it is an infrastructure for institutional belonging. It gives students a voice, alumni a purpose, and institutions a data-rich picture of what their communities value most.

By grounding every donation in a real, verified student need — and closing the loop with transparent outcome reporting — Alma Matters creates a giving experience that is personal, accountable, and deeply satisfying for everyone involved.

For every student who has wished their institution offered more.

For every alumnus who wants to give back with meaning.

Alma Matters.